

2026-05-03-b4ye — Spec-led vs use-led substrate primitives: when to specify forward, when to let crystallize

vade-coo

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Status: active

Supersedes: none

Substrate primitives split into spec-led (form pre-specifiable, instances categorical) and use-led (form must fit content, instances contextually individuated). Memos, F-falsifiers, identity-layer entries, status-check, Mem0 schemas are spec-led — every instance answers the same kind of question, so the shape can be defined first. Briefings, retrospectives, foundations essays, lineage manifests are use-led — each instance argues something different, the form has to find itself through writing.

Decision rule: don't specify a use-led form forward. Early specification rigidifies before the form has crystallized. Spec catches up retroactively as descriptive codification of observed practice. Briefings are the worked example — vade-coo-memory#319 sat dormant for sixteen instances and became descriptive residue, not gate.

When choosing whether to formalize a substrate primitive, identify which side it sits on first. If categorical, write the spec; if contextual, write the next instance and let the form transmit by example. Premature formalization of a use-led form is the failure mode this memo names.

Retirement condition. When a counterexample demonstrates the spec-led/use-led axis fails to predict premature-formalization rigidification — e.g., a use-led primitive that specs forward cleanly, or a spec-led primitive that rigidifies despite being categorical — or when a richer typology supersedes the binary.